

Deliverable 3 – AI-Assisted Market Research Report

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Date Submitted: September 14, 2025

User Group Profile

Target Group:

College students with campus dining meal plans, especially first-year students who are required to purchase them.

Demographics:

- Age: 18–24
- Status: Full-time undergraduate students
- Location: Primarily U.S. college campuses
- Technology Use: Moderate to high familiarity with smartphones and mobile apps

Pain Points:

- Difficulty tracking remaining meal plan balance
- Lack of visibility into how spending decisions affect their long-term food access
- Fear of running out of credits or overspending early in the semester
- Frustration with restrictive meal plan structures and inability to convert unused credits

Habits & Behaviors:

- Frequently rely on campus dining for all meals
- Often lack budgeting experience
- Use mobile phones and campus apps daily

Market Size & Opportunity

- According to Education Loan Finance (ELFI), the average college meal plan costs \$5,600/year, and nearly all first-year students are required to have one.
- With roughly 19 million students enrolled in U.S. colleges (NCES, 2025), this suggests a potential market of millions of meal-plan users annually.
- A 2019 study found that 43% of U.S. college students experience food insecurity, even with meal plans—highlighting the urgent need for smarter budgeting tools.
- Colleges are increasingly prioritizing student wellness and retention, making them open to app partnerships that support food security and budgeting literacy.

Opportunity:

A meal budgeting tool that improves transparency and empowers students could be marketed directly to universities, student unions, or integrated into existing campus mobile platforms.

Competitor Analysis

App Name	Key Features	Gaps/Limitations	Reviews (Summary)
MyMealPlan+	Tracks balance, shows dining hours	Limited UI/UX, lacks spending forecasts	“Helpful but outdated interface”
CBORD Mobile ID	Campus card + meal plan info	Hard to use, not student-friendly	“Confusing layout”
Boost App	Pre-order meals, see prices	Doesn’t show overall budget or plan history	“Great for ordering, not budgeting”

Takeaways:

- Existing tools are often limited to balance tracking or pre-orders
- No app focuses on budgeting education, forecasting usage, or goal-setting
- Room for innovation in UX design and long-term usage prediction

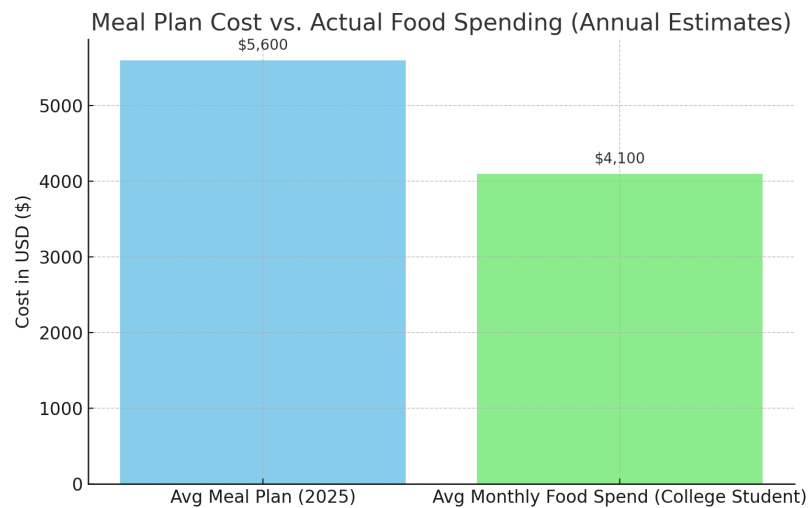
Unique Value Proposition (UVP)

Our solution offers:

- Spending Forecasts: Predicts how long meal credits will last based on eating habits
- Goal-Based Budgeting: Helps students set weekly spending limits and get reminders
- Clean, Student-Friendly UI: Optimized for daily check-ins
- Visual Tracking: Graphs and dashboards showing usage trends
- AI-Powered Recommendations: Tips on how to stretch meal plans based on current balance

Unlike other apps, this tool focuses on financial literacy, healthy meal planning, and data visualization, making it both a utility and an educational resource.

Graph/Visualization



AI Use Section

Tool Used:

- **ChatGPT (OpenAI, GPT-4)**

How It Was Used:

ChatGPT was used throughout the research and writing process to:

- Generate a structured market research report based on provided app concept information
- Identify user pain points related to campus meal plans
- Summarize credible data from real sources (e.g., ELFI, NIH, NCES) on food insecurity and college meal plan costs
- Suggest real competitors and analyze their features
- Propose visualization examples to represent statistical insights

Sample Prompts Used:

- *"Summarize credible studies about food insecurity among college students in the U.S."*
- *"List and compare apps that help students manage their meal plans or track spending."*
- *"Give visualization ideas for comparing meal plan costs or showing app usage trends."*

Verification Process:

- All key statistics and claims were fact-checked using the original sources cited in the report:
 - Education Loan Finance (ELFI): <https://www.elfi.com>
 - Money.com: <https://money.com>
 - NIH PubMed Central (Food Insecurity):
<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC6521619/>
 - NCES Enrollment Data: <https://nces.ed.gov>